

with the Indian engineers.

But when I landed in India in 2013, things were a little different. I went to Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), National Informatics Centre (NIC), Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), Infosys and Wipro. Those meetings were 'tyre kicking' exercises for us. People had no plans to move from a proprietary solution.

By 2017, the Indian open source space has been majorly transformed. NIC is already developing major projects with Postgres. So is the case with C-DAC and India-headquartered IT companies like Infosys, TCS and Wipro. So, now, we can say that people here have started investing in open source.

Q What happens at the EnterpriseDB Open Source Centre in Pune? And how critical is it from a global perspective?

We have had our Pune Open Source Centre since 2007. Originally, the Pune centre was mostly for technical support, engineering and building software, managing training and managing financing. So it was initially a big back office for us. But within a couple of years, it became clear to our team that there was a significant market in India. So we started initiating sales and established backend engineering.

Nowadays, the Open Source Centre is not only supporting local teams but is also building solutions for the global markets. We can say that the growth in Pune is much quicker, and there is a lot of talent there to enable engineering, support, training components, sales and marketing.

Q How do you see the entrance of Microsoft SQL Server in the world of open source?

Microsoft has fought against open source for a long time, but it is good to see that its management team has seen the error of its ways. I am unclear what impact the addition of Microsoft SQL Server on Linux will be. However, it still has the baggage of being a proprietary database.

Q What is next in Postgres?

The next release is coming out in September or October of this year. This version will be Postgres 10 and will include big things like logic replication, increased parallelism and the initial building blocks for sharding. Moreover, it should have 220-230 new features.

Q What, do you think, is the future of open source database management systems?

Data storage needs are changing rapidly as applications become more demanding. Open source databases are in an ideal position to lead innovation by integrating data from different data storage solutions and process using a distributed architecture. I think Postgres has already started in that area.

Q In this entire journey, was there ever a make or break situation for the team?

When I am with the core team members, I am always paranoid

and have fears like what are all the risks, how could we get exposed and what are the terrible things that can happen? Just a year ago, I used to have thoughts that some large companies would come along and just hire all our key engineers. But, now, I do not think this is going to happen in the future. We have a good distribution of companies, we are not exposed to only one or two firms, and we have a large number of volunteers.

I was also scared in the recent past that some of our assets would get compromised and some of the important credentials would be leaked. Likewise, patents are my major point of concern. It is not an issue in India, but a vital thing in the US. Software patents in the US market are so broad that it is difficult to know whether you are infringing or not.

Having said that, I am not sure that I see any risks now, in working on Postgres.

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By any measure—features,
performance, usability and
reliability—Postgres is ahead of
MySQL and has been for years.
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Q Lastly, what would be the key learning that you would like to share with other communities trying to drive their own open source projects?

There was a six-month period years ago, when I kind of backed out of all my projects. I did not get involved in emails and would get worked up when I saw unusual things happening in the open source world. I felt then that the harmony that we had in the past had disintegrated, and I could not bring myself to re-engage with the community. What I learnt from that experience is that the leadership of the group has to really set a tone that is balanced.

Russian author Leo Tolstoy said, “All happy families are alike; each unhappy family is unhappy in its own way.” A happy open source project really has to have all the things in all the right measures to really thrive.

A lot of open source communities have been dysfunctional. Sometimes they become dysfunctional because their leaders get too strong, or sometimes because there is a lack of structure and the individuals start fighting against each other. That can become a major problem for growth.

You need to set a tone where everyone in the community feels valued and considers that all their contributions matter, and that this is part of something that is important to their lives.

People can only contribute to a project in a community if they feel like this is the best use of their time, and this is what they can do well in their life. That happens only when you have the kind of community we have, which makes people feel this way, very effectively.

So, the more you empower people, the more dedication you will receive from them to uplift the community. 